

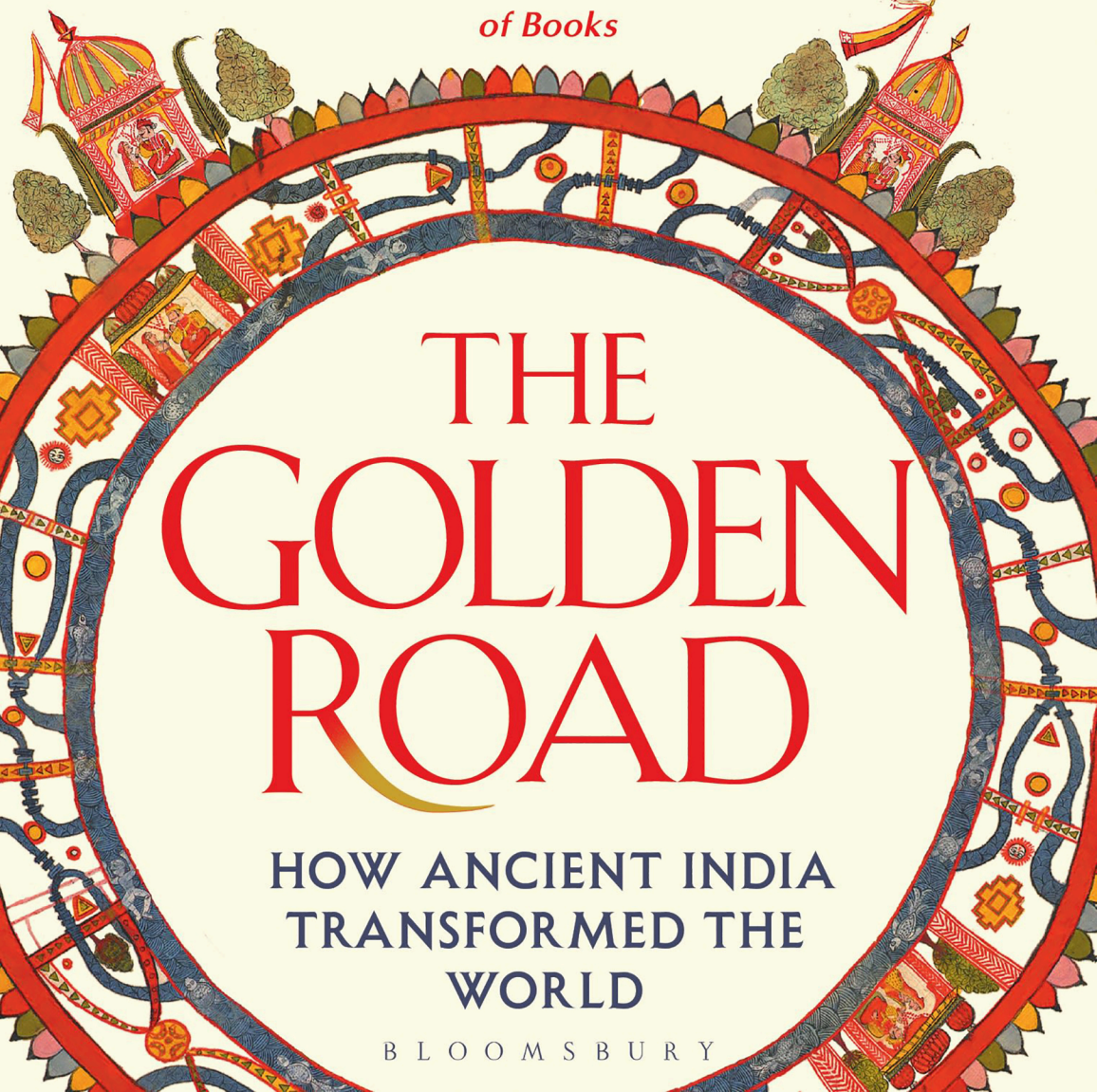
THE SUNDAY TIMES BESTSELLER

WILLIAM DALRYMPLE

‘Outstanding’
Financial Times

‘Compelling’
*London Review
of Books*

‘Dazzling’
Guardian



THE GOLDEN ROAD

HOW ANCIENT INDIA
TRANSFORMED THE
WORLD

BLOOMSBURY

A 2024 BOOK OF THE YEAR FOR *THE TIMES*, *SPECTATOR*,
HISTORY TODAY AND WATERSTONES

‘Dazzling ... Dalrymple is a born storyteller, with a wonderful facility for expounding complex events with verve and clarity ... *The Golden Road*, teeming with his own evocative descriptions of far-flung cave and forest temples, sculptures and wall paintings, is not just a historical study but also a love letter – to a lost syncretic world of interacting and evolving religious creeds and intellectual movements, when Indian ideas transformed the world’ Fara Dabhoiwala, *Guardian*

‘As always his enthusiasm is infectious ... A brisk and lively telling, brimming with memorable characters and skilled evocations of Buddhist art ... A richly woven, highly readable account of the highlights of India’s outsized influence on the world ... Written with passion and verve and hinting at an optimism for India’s future of which Tagore himself would no doubt heartily have approved’ *Spectator*

‘An outstanding new account of ancient India’s cultural conquest of the globe ... Xi Jinping’s China is currently much better at promoting itself as the heart of Asia. But it may ultimately prove no match for India’s primordial gift for myth and narrative, and this is what Dalrymple has so successfully channelled into *The Golden Road* ... The most compelling retelling we have had for generations’ *Financial Times*

‘The history book that will transform your view of early civilisation ... Forget the Silk Roads, it’s the Golden Road we should be celebrating. Dalrymple argues that, thanks to its major role in global trade between AD 300 and 600, it’s India, rather than China, to which we owe some of the most important developments in human civilisation ... A multifarious and engaging narrative, which, like Indian trade, takes us in many directions, peppered with lively stories and charismatic individuals. It will make you look at the world differently’ *Independent*

‘Riveting ... With the trained eye of an art historian and accomplished travel writer, Dalrymple has an overwhelmingly visual style, taking paintings, statues, temples, archaeological digs and manuscripts as his landmarks in this sprawling history of the long millennium. He leads the reader along a revolutionary road that until now has remained obscured in works of history wrought by contemporary nationalism, geopolitical conflicts and, above all, European conceit ... A standout contribution ... Dalrymple instead focuses

on the enduring and alluring power of ideas in shaping the ancient world ... Stunning ... In brilliantly excavating the Golden Road in the current age of the Silk Road, Dalrymple's book is both contemporary and altogether foreign' Shruti Kapila, *New Statesman*

'Dalrymple's own odyssey is equally laden to the gunwales with pages of astounding illustrations and arresting anecdotes, but its destination is always clear and its argument compelling ... An eirenic exploration ... It's a valuable achievement to shunt off the Silk Road into a permanent siding, but Dalrymple's book has deeper and even more provoking resonances, which indirectly challenge the way history is usually written' Ferdinand Mount, *London Review of Books*

'After writing a string of award-winning books on India, the historian and literary phenomenon William Dalrymple has forsaken the glamour of the Mughals and the murky dealings of the English East India Company to look beyond the Indian subcontinent and make the case for the existence of a wider, pre-Islamic "Indosphere" ... A more masterful and accessible survey of a "world-changing" traffic in commodities, creeds, scientific insights and artistic conventions than *The Golden Road* would be hard to find. The only surprise is that it has taken Dalrymple so long to address the subject. No one is better qualified to do so ... The breadth of Dalrymple's research is a revelation and a delight ... What Tagore called "the Greater India outside India" knew no boundaries. Neither does this enthralling study' John Keay, *Literary Review*

'This is a book that should not be missed by anyone interested in the world of ancient Indian cultures ... Thanks to Dalrymple, India's contribution will be known to the entire English-speaking world, and the West's almost deliberate obliviousness exposed. There are a few aspects of Dalrymple's riveting narrative – and he writes with enviable elegance and lucidity – that demand to be drawn out. One is that there is a history outside politics, palaces and battlefields. The power of ideas does not necessarily always flow from the barrels of guns. Ideas have their own momentum and trajectory that can be tracked, as Dalrymple does with immersive research and reading. Dalrymple's book is a remarkable feat of intellectual retrieval. He has brought to life an India that most people, outside a narrow band of specialists, know little about' Rudrangshu Mukherjee, *Business Standard*

'One of India's foremost historians, deeply connected to the country he calls home ... An epic narrative exploring India's profound influence on the world, particularly through its contributions to mathematics, religion and trade.

This work showcases the “astonishing gifts” India has given humanity, weaving together historical threads that have often been overlooked or misunderstood’ *Eastern Eye*

‘A powerful and sweeping account ... To read *The Golden Road* is like opening a magic box – packed with strange and absorbing characters, quirky and almost-forgotten narratives, startling and uncommon facts ... Once again, Dalrymple demonstrates that rare ability to use primary historical sources to make places and people come alive and show that it is possible to write about the past in a way that is at once consequential and extremely engaging’ Mukund Padmanabhan, *Hindu*

‘An erudite and wonderfully entertaining [historian] ... This is a wonderful book. Read it through in delight, acquiring knowledge, perhaps even wisdom. Then you will surely return to read much of it again’ Allan Massie, *Scotsman*

‘A bold, sweeping narrative ... Where Dalrymple’s scholarship breaks new ground is to link the eastern and western branches of this Indosphere in a coherent and highly readable narrative ... Dalrymple’s book is also timely. Cultural and religious pluralism drove the ideas and innovations that sustained the Golden Road – raising the question, as Dalrymple does in his conclusion: can India do so again?’ John Zubrzycki, *Australian*

‘In exquisite prose, Dalrymple outlines the influence of the subcontinent upon global technology, astronomy, art, religion, music, mathematics, literature and mythology ... Hugely ambitious, dazzling’ *BBC History Magazine*

‘Makes accessible a tremendous amount of detailed and sometimes even obscure – but important – research undertaken in the past thirty years, from literary studies to history and archaeology. Even those familiar with Indian history will discover a host of hidden gems of scholarship in the endnotes and bibliography. The research is wide-ranging and impressive ... Engrossing material ... brought together so masterfully and beautifully’ Daud Ali, *TLS*

‘Anybody who’s interested not only in the history of India, but really in the history of the entire world, should be reading this’ *Monocle*, Meet the Writers

‘In his masterful new work ... Dalrymple argues that India has both the potential and the historical track record to catch up with its former peer to the northeast. Citing compelling evidence, Dalrymple notes that many of the great advances in human history originated from Indian civilization, particularly in mathematics (including the concept of zero), religion (Hinduism and Buddhism) and philosophy, astronomy, medicine, literature and art.

He argues that the world overlooked India's vast influence, and that trade routes emanating from India may have had an equally substantive impact on Asian and world history as the Chinese silk route. India was "a crucial economic fulcrum, and civilizational engine, at the heart of the ancient and early medieval worlds," Dalrymple writes, describing the country as "one of the main motors of global trade and cultural transmission." *The Golden Road* fills an important gap in our understanding ... [It] couldn't be more timely. *The Golden Road* is not only a reminder of a glorious past; it can also inspire Indians to match the sterling record of their ancestors in engaging a new rejuvenated continent – and claim the leadership of the Asian Century' Kishore Mahbubani, *Bloomberg*

'Modern India has not told her ancient tale well either to herself or the world, a task newly accomplished by William Dalrymple's book, *The Golden Road* ... Nobody has done this since A. L. Basham in *The Wonder That Was India* in 1954 ... Written very engagingly, often drawing from new finds in archaeology and artefacts, the book recreates what Dalrymple names the "Indosphere"' Renuka Narayanan, *Hindustan Times*

'Any new book by William Dalrymple is a literary event, and his latest ... is no exception' Eugene Rogan, *History Today*, Books of the Year

'A book as glorious as its name implies ... Superbly engaging ... Joyous' *Irish Times*

'In sum, Dalrymple has pulled off a great service to the history of the world, which is largely unknown out west and to many in India. As he says, European school children know about Archimedes but not about Aryabhata, the Indian whose numbers they use ... Armed with luminous prose, memorable historical characters, and heavily documented events, Dalrymple ... offers a compelling read' Sharmila Purkayastha, *Telegraph*

'Grand and gripping' *UnHerd*

'William Dalrymple breathes life into a glorious era of the Indic world, one that was chronicled by the likes of Xuanzang and many others. Known for his bestselling narrative nonfiction on Indian history, Dalrymple captivates readers once again with his storytelling mastery. What sets *The Golden Road* apart from his previous works is its vast thematic scope – recounting the grandest story he has ever attempted ... Entertaining and thought-provoking. With its vast thematic scope and historical breadth, it is inevitable that some of Dalrymple's arguments will ignite intense debate – yet this very aspect makes his work all the more invaluable ... Stands as a remarkable scholarly

achievement, illuminating one of the most misunderstood and misrepresented periods of Indian history, while making it accessible to a wide audience' Ajay Saini, *Outlook*

'In India, we have not yet focussed on maritime history as essential to the understanding of our past. There has been a fixation with land and events within the country's present-day boundaries. And yet, one cannot fully comprehend peninsular India's personality without recognising the role of the sea. *The Golden Road* gently offers such a reorientation so that we approach Indian history with a far more zoomed-out lens. Or as Dalrymple writes, "In the ancient and medieval world, the sea did not divide so much as unite"' Manu Pillai, *Frontline*

'A belated eulogy to "an empire of ideas" that had developed into "a tangible 'Indosphere"''. It is as much remembrance and celebration as introduction ... The book is essential reading' *Open*

'As always, Dalrymple writes with great knowledge and verve, and with telling details' *Church Times*

'Dalrymple's capacious and absorbing portrayal of this period of soft power blends recent archaeological discoveries with short accounts of his own travels, along with an abundance of archival sources ... Broad historical currents are leavened with engrossing portraits of influential individuals over the ages ... Earlier works like *White Mughals* and *The Anarchy* have amply demonstrated Dalrymple's skill in portraying times of confluence, collaboration and conjunction: eras during which one way of life collides with and blends into another. *The Golden Road* is another fascinating addition to the list' Sanjay Sipahimalani, *Deccan Herald*

'Riveting ... Substantial and extremely readable ... *The Golden Road* takes a keen interest in the complex logistics of cultural transmission from India to countries separated from it by seas, mountains and deserts ... Told with the brio Dalrymple has always brought to tales of bloody court intrigue ... As Dalrymple vividly shows, the real interest in his story lies not in the mere fact that Indian ideas reached foreign shores, but in what the avid Indophiles of south-east Asia and the Middle East did with the ideas they borrowed ... A breezy, often breathless, survey that works by accumulating details and spotting connections' *Daily Telegraph*

'A wonderful storyteller, he'll make you fall in love with India all over again' *Indian Link*

‘Convincingly chronicles the many core ideas and innovations that originated in the Indian subcontinent ... Dalrymple is at his artful best in his account of how the knowledge of several mathematical concepts and astronomical discoveries passed from ancient India to eighth-century Baghdad through an eccentric family of Muslim royal viziers who had once been rectors in a Buddhist monastery in Afghanistan’ *Observer*

‘This enchanting work of ancient history offers an important backdrop to understanding contemporary India ... Dalrymple finds another India in the past: open to trade, tolerant, scientific, creative and universalist’ Pratap Banu Mehta, *Foreign Affairs*

WILLIAM DALRYMPLE is one of Britain's great historians and the bestselling author of the Wolfson Prize-winning *White Mughals*, *The Last Mughal*, which won the Duff Cooper Prize, and the Hemingway and Kapuściński Prize-winning *Return of a King*. *The Anarchy* won the Arthur Ross Book Award medal from the US Council on Foreign Relations. A frequent broadcaster, he has written and presented three television series, one of which won the Grierson Award for Best Documentary Series at BAFTA. He has also won the Thomas Cook Travel Book Award, the *Sunday Times* Young British Writer of the Year Award, the Foreign Correspondent of the Year at the FPA Media Awards, and been awarded six honorary doctorates. He is a fellow of the Royal Society of Literature, the Royal Asiatic Society, the Royal Society of Edinburgh, and has held visiting fellowships at Princeton, Brown and All Souls College, University of Oxford. He writes regularly for the *New York Review of Books*, the *New Yorker* and the *Guardian*. In 2018 he was presented with the prestigious President's Medal by the British Academy for his outstanding literary achievement and for co-founding the Jaipur Literature Festival. He is the co-host of chart-topping podcast *Empire* with Anita Anand. William lives with his wife and three children on a goat farm outside Delhi.

WILLIAM
DALRYMPLE

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HOW ANCIENT INDIA
TRANSFORMED THE
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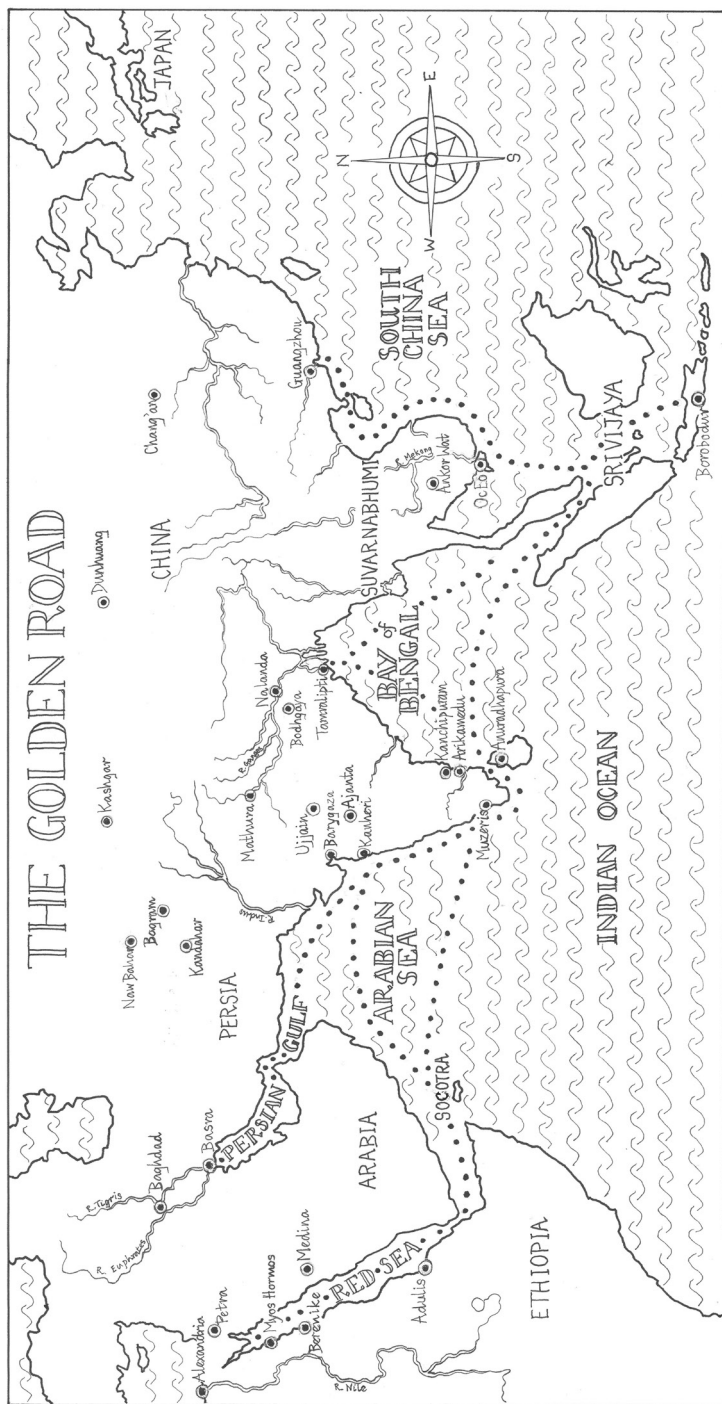
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For Rob & Anna,
and to the memory of my much-missed friend
and beloved colleague, Bruce Wannell

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Introduction

The Indosphere

‘People of distant places, with diverse customs,’ wrote a Chinese Buddhist monk in the early seventh century CE, ‘generally designate the land they most admire as India.’¹

Xuanzang was one of China’s greatest scholars, travellers and translators. When he wrote these words, he had just returned from an epic seventeen-year, 6,000-mile overland pilgrimage to the great Indian centres of learning. The account he wrote of that journey, *The Great Tang Records on the Western Regions*, makes it clear that the world he had just passed through, from Chang’an in western China to Kanchipuram in southern India, and back, was largely dominated by Indic ideas, art, science, languages and religions. In particular, he looked with profound reverence at India’s ancient Buddhist university monasteries, such as Nalanda, with their tens of thousands of learned monks. For Xuanzang they were simply the greatest centres of knowledge and scholarship in the world, the Indian equivalent of the great Library of Alexandria.

Lectures at Nalanda were given in a hundred different halls each day, he wrote, ‘and the students studied diligently without wasting a single moment’.² He described the lecture halls, the stupa relic mound, five temples and 300 apartments and dormitories which housed the

10,000 monks and international scholars who gathered there.³ Between them they studied the texts of the different schools of Buddhism, as well as the sacred Vedas, logic, Sanskrit grammar, philosophy, medicine, metaphysics, divination, mathematics, astronomy, literature and magic. 'The priests of Nalanda, to the number of several thousands, are men of the highest ability and talent,' he wrote. 'Their distinction is very great at the present time. The day is not sufficient for asking and answering profound questions. From morning until night they engage in discussions; the old and the young mutually help each other.'⁴

Above all, he described the glories of Nalanda's library, which he regarded as the greatest repository of knowledge in the world. It was nine storeys high and contained three divisions: the Ratnadadhi, the 'Sea of Jewels', the Ratnasagara, the 'Ocean of Jewels', and the Ratnaranjaka, the 'Jewel-Adorned'. Any manuscript could be borrowed, though Nalanda regulations held that it must be stored in the niche in the monks' cells next to the square central courtyard.⁵ Here it was that Xuanzang studied for five industrious years, copying out by hand the Sanskrit manuscripts he wished to take back home to China. Later, these manuscripts would be translated, and recopied many more times, carried on to monasteries around China, Korea and Japan.

For most of late medieval and modern history, India was on the receiving end of a great deal of cultural influence from beyond its borders. Following the establishment of a series of Islamic sultanates throughout India in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries, Persian became the language of government across much of India, and Persianate cultural standards, in art, dress and etiquette, became dominant even in southern Hindu courts. Then, in the nineteenth century, during the rise of the East India Company and the Victorian Raj, English gradually replaced Persian, and India became instead part of the Anglosphere. To master English was now the route to advancement, and Indians who wished to get ahead had to abandon, or at least sublimate, much of their own culture, becoming instead English-speaking 'Brown Sahibs', or what V. S. Naipaul called 'Mimic Men'. In time, of course, Indians became masters in both languages, adopting Persian and English as their own, and, just as Bedil Dehlavi became one of the most admired Persian poets in seventeenth-century Central Asia, so many Indian writers from Tagore to Rushdie, as well as Naipaul himself, became literary superstars in English in the twentieth.

But for a millennium and a half before then, from about 250 BCE to 1200 CE, India was a confident exporter of its own diverse civilisation, creating around it an empire of ideas which developed into a tangible 'Indosphere' where its cultural influence was predominant. During this period, the rest of Asia was the willing and even eager recipient of a startlingly comprehensive mass transfer of Indian soft power, in religion, art, music, dance, textiles, technology, astronomy, mathematics, medicine, mythology, language and literature.

Sanskrit had been a profoundly sacred tongue for at least a millennium before the Common Era, but at some point between the first century BCE and the first century CE, Sanskrit was reinvented as a literary and political language, the start of an astonishing transformation of its use that saw Sanskrit literary culture rapidly spread all the way from Afghanistan to Java. Indeed, in time, as Sheldon Pollock has shown, Sanskrit, 'the Language of the Gods in the World of Men', became the lingua franca across much of Asia and left a permanent mark on the map from Balkh (Sanskrit Bahlika) to Singapore (Sanskrit Simhapura). The name 'Java', for example, derives from the Sanskrit Yavad dvipa, meaning 'the island shaped like a *yava*', or grain of barley. Indeed, so deeply immersed in Sanskritic culture did the elites of South-east Asia become that they began renaming their towns and settlements after the most celebrated places of Indian mythology.⁶ To this day, the ancient capital of Thailand is named Ayutthaya after Ayodhya, Lord Rama's capital in the great epic poem the *Ramayana*, while the national airline of Indonesia is Garuda, named after the god Vishnu's mount. The spread of Sanskrit brought all of Indian literature, arts and the sciences in its wake.

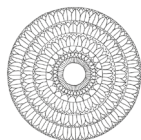
Out of India came not just pioneering merchants, astronomers and astrologers, scientists and mathematicians, doctors and sculptors, but also the holy men, monks and missionaries of several distinct strands of Indic religious thought and devotion – Vedic, Shaiva and Vaishnava Hinduism, or Sanatana Dharma as some prefer to call it, as well as Theravada, Mahayana and Tantric Buddhism.

These different religious worlds sometimes mingled and melded, sometimes competed; occasionally, they clashed. But between them they came to dominate South, Central, South-east and Eastern Asia. Over half the world's population today lives in areas where Indian ideas of religion and culture are, or once were, dominant, and where Indian gods ruled the imaginations and the aspirations of men and

women. Meanwhile India's intellectual influence travelled far to the west, giving us not only crucial mathematical concepts such as zero, but also the very form of the numbers we all use to this day. This is arguably the nearest thing the human race has to a universal language.

Indian learning, Indian religious insights and Indian ideas are among the crucial foundations of our world. Like ancient Greece, ancient India came up with a set of profound answers to the big questions about what the world is, how it operates, why we are here and how we should live our lives. What Greece was first to Rome, then to the rest of the Mediterranean and European world, so at this period India was to South-east and Central Asia and even to China, radiating out and diffusing its philosophies, political ideas and architectural forms out over an entire region, not by conquest but instead by sheer cultural allure and sophistication. In matters of science, astronomy and mathematics, India was to be a teacher of the Arab world, and hence Mediterranean Europe too.

This entire spectrum of early Indian influence has always been there, hiding in plain sight: in the Buddhism of Sri Lanka, Tibet, China, Korea and Japan, in the place names of Burma and Thailand, in the murals and sculptures of the *Ramayana* and the *Mahabharata* in Laos and Cambodia, in the Hindu gods, rituals and temples of Bali. Yet somehow the Golden Road linking all these diverse forms and geographies into a single cultural unit, a vast Indosphere stretching all the way from the Red Sea to the Pacific, has never been recognised as the link connecting all these different places and ideas to each other; and up to now has never been given a name.⁷



Thanks to the winds of the Asian monsoon, India lies at the centre of a great network of navigable sea roads and maritime trade routes.

Every summer, the heating of the Tibetan plateau creates an area of low pressure which sucks in moist, cool winds from the Bay of Bengal. Every winter, cold dry winds rake out from the snows of the Himalayas to the warm seas beyond. The Indian peninsula sits in the middle of this vortex of winds which blow one way for six months

a year, then reverse themselves for the next six. The regularity and predictability of these winds generate monsoons that have allowed millennia of Indian sailors to raise their sails and propel themselves at speed across the oceans that surround them; then, when the winds reverse, safely back again.⁸

Early Indian traders used the sea roads of monsoon Asia to travel in two directions. Many headed westwards on the winter winds to the east coast of Africa and the rich kingdoms of Ethiopia. Here they had a choice. One northern fork led through the Persian Gulf to Iran and Mesopotamia; the other, to its south, via Aden, took them through the Red Sea to Egypt. Indian traders heading west used to arrive with the trade winds in early summer and ride the summer monsoon home in August; with the winds behind you, the journey from the mouth of the Red Sea to Gujarat could take as little as forty days, though if you missed the winds the round trip might take as long as a year, and cause you to take a prolonged holiday on the Nile.⁹ The equivalent overland route by camel caravan through Afghanistan would take at least three times as long.¹⁰

For 300 years, from the time of the Battle of Actium in 31 BCE and the integration of Egypt into the Roman imperial system, the main arteries of early east–west travel lay less overland, through a Persia often at war with Rome, and much more across the Golden Road of the open oceans, via the choppy waters of the Red Sea and the Indian Ocean.

As Kaludayin, an early Buddhist monk and contemporary of the Buddha, noted, what propelled men over these dangerous waters was simply the lure of gold and the desire for wealth.¹¹ Through these waters passed boatload after boatload of Indian exports, while in reverse the wealth of Rome drained into Indian pockets. In the first century the puritanical Roman naval commander Pliny the Elder describes India as ‘the sink of the world’s most precious metals ... There is no year which does not drain our empire of at least fifty-five million sesterces ... So great is the labour employed, and so distant is the region drawn upon, to enable the Roman matron to flaunt see-through clothes in public ... Thus is India brought near: by greed, and women’s decadent need to follow fashion.’¹²

According to Pliny’s near contemporary the Greek geographer Strabo, Roman control of Egypt quickly led to a sixfold increase in

the shipping heading to India compared to the Ptolemaic period preceding it: 'when Gallus was prefect of Egypt, I accompanied him and ascended the Nile as far as Syene and the frontiers of Ethiopia,' he wrote. Here 'I learned that as many as one hundred and twenty vessels were sailing from Myos Hormos to India, whereas formerly, under the Ptolemies, only a very few ventured to undertake the voyage and to carry on traffic in Indian merchandise.'¹³ Some economic historians now estimate that such was the scale of the Red Sea trade at this period that the customs taxes raised by Roman officials on the trade coming through the Red Sea would alone have covered around one-third of the entire revenues that the Roman Empire required to administer its global conquests and maintain its legions, from Scotland to the borders of Persia and from the Sahara to the banks of the Rhine and Danube.¹⁴

This initial boom lasted for a century, and the trade continued at a slightly reduced rate for another 300 years. But the fall of the Western Roman Empire and the fraying and decay of much of urban life in northern and western Europe in the early fifth century CE was followed by the incessant wars between Byzantium and Persia in the sixth. The Red Sea port of Myos Hormos was already in terminal decline by the fourth century; its rival, Berenike, was abandoned around 550, possibly finished off by an outbreak of the Justinianic plague.¹⁵

As supplies of gold from the west to India fell catastrophically in the fourth and fifth centuries CE, a major realignment of Indian overseas trade began to take place. If gold was no longer arriving in massive quantities from Rome, then Indian merchants, often managed and marshalled by a series of newly founded trading guilds, began bringing it instead from the long coastlines and islands of Suvarnabhumi, the 'Lands of Gold'.¹⁶

In what is now Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Malaysia, Thailand, Laos, Vietnam and Cambodia, new urban centres were springing to life; and Indian traders were sailing there with every eastward monsoon, carrying cargoes of beads, textiles, metal goods and other Indian manufactures which they exchanged for spices, gold, camphor, resin and the other raw materials of the region. By the fifth century a major direct sea route had been established through the Straits of Malacca which easily linked the southern and eastern oceans, so taking Indian traders swiftly to China.¹⁷

Today, in a world divided by national boundaries, we think of Cambodia as very far from India. But in the ancient and medieval world, the sea did not divide so much as unite, and with the summer monsoon winds working in your favour and blowing you ever further eastwards, they made travel over large distances not just possible but remarkably fast. As the western branch of the Golden Road closed up, the revived eastern branch began to replace it in importance. The monsoon winds brought the two sides of the Bay of Bengal into ever closer contact, drawing them together into a single cultural and geographical unit within the Indosphere.

By the first century CE, the journey by merchant ship from the port city of Tamralipti in Bengal to Sri Lanka took only a fortnight; from there to Sumatra was a journey of three weeks, and the passage on to Guangzhou in China took less than a month. Using the winds of the monsoon it would have been much quicker to have travelled from southern India to Java, the Mekong Delta or the mouth of the Yangtze than it would to travel overland to, say, Ujjain in central India or to Kashmir.

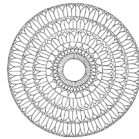
The great Indian epics talk of Suvarnabhumi – the eastern coast of the Bay of Bengal – as an eastern El Dorado where fortunes were there for the picking. The *Ramayana* also mentions Suvarnadvipa, the ‘Islands of Gold’, and the seven kingdoms of the ‘gold and silver islands’ beyond Sri Lanka, the Indonesian archipelago, all with fabulous mines groaning with riches. ‘There,’ says the Monkey King Sugriva, ‘precious metals could be drawn from the earth as easily as mud elsewhere.’¹⁸

There is growing archaeological evidence that Indian merchants even brought with them skilled artisans to refine on site and to work the gold they bought in Sumatra, Borneo, the Malay peninsula and Thailand. At the early temple site of Krabi in Thailand, archaeologists recently found a goldsmith’s touchstone etched with the earliest Tamil inscription in South-east Asia; it is written in the Tamil-Brahmi script of the first to third century CE, and proclaims itself the property of ‘Perumpatan’ – the ‘Great Goldsmith’. Nearby were found gold coins with a bull on the front and a double-masted ship on the reverse.¹⁹ Elsewhere in Thailand, the recent discovery of a third-century BCE jewellery mould along with four thin circular gold foils in a distinctly Indian style suggests that Indian jewellers were at work here as early as the Mauryan period, in the third century BCE.²⁰

The craftsmen stayed on in Suvarnabhumi because, quite simply, gold was everywhere. This was a world of immense wealth. At excavations on the Mekong delta site of Oc Eo, one of the first major trading cities in South-east Asia, gold jewellery and ornaments were dug up by French archaeologists in dazzling profusion: inlaid gold rings, engraved gold plaques and gold *triratna* ‘three jewels’ medallions, gold earrings in the shape of a bow, twelve-sided gold beads and gold ornaments in the shape of lotus flowers, even golden snakes. Indeed, in just a few seasons of digging, archaeologists found 1,300 gold objects. Small droplets of gold were found in many trenches, indicating that gold working had actually taken place on the site. As the archaeologists dug down, they felt they had rediscovered the Lands of Gold.²¹

In time, these links would transform the region as South-east Asia became part of the Sanskrit-speaking world, and adopted and adapted for its own use Indic gods, religions and scripts, epics and plays, forms of architecture and ways of thinking about and enumerating the world. Even the place names began to be modelled on originals on the far side of the Bay of Bengal. It was not just that Indian gods had been welcomed into a region: even the landscape itself was being reimaged. The holy rivers of India, the apocalyptic battlefield of the *Mahabharata* and the great palaces of the *Ramayana* were now being imaginatively built anew many thousands of miles to the east of India, in the paddy fields of the Mekong and amid the volcanoes of Java.

By the sixth or seventh century CE, in other words, South-east Asia had become a central part of the Indosphere.



The Golden Road aims to highlight India's often forgotten position as a crucial economic fulcrum, and civilisational engine, at the heart of the ancient and early medieval worlds and as one of the main motors of global trade and cultural transmission in early world history, fully on a par with and equal to China.

Over the course of more than a thousand years, Indian religions, philosophies and sciences spread out in all directions across the Indosphere, like the shifting rays of a Sanskritic sun that sometimes

penetrated surprisingly deeply into far distant recesses of the world around it. The book tells the story of the diffusion of transformative Indian ideas first around Asia, then around the wider world, focusing on three systems of Indian thought that emerged when it was the focal point of a sphere of influence that reached all the way from Afghanistan to Japan, with ripples lapping westwards to the distant shores of the Mediterranean.

The Golden Road first explores the birth of Buddhism in the fifth century BCE as a usually non-violent and relatively egalitarian movement that rose as part of a great philosophical churning and transformation, partly in reaction, on one hand, to early Vedic Hinduism, with its strict caste hierarchies and its mass sacrifice of animals, and, on the other, to the harsh austerities of the ascetic Jains. It will follow Buddhism's sudden leap to prominence under the Emperor Ashoka, who helped consolidate Buddhism as a pan-Indian religion and who sent missionaries around the world to spread the *dharma* – the path of duty and morality. It will then tell the history of the spread of Buddhism into Tibet and China, transforming culture, life and thought, a process which culminated in it becoming the court religion through the influence of the remarkable Wu Zetian, the first and only female Emperor of China. Today, despite all the trials of its recent history, China still has the largest numbers of practising Buddhists in the world.

From the Chinese court, Buddhism quickly spread further east, becoming the major religion in Korea and bringing with it a spectrum of Indian ideas ranging from martial arts to Zen meditation. These new Zen (Sanskrit Dhyana) Buddhist teachings would flourish there, before spreading still further east in the late sixth century CE to Asuka-era (593–710) Japan. Here they would in time form the philosophical base for cultural expressions as diverse as the haiku, delicate ink washes of Japanese landscapes and even Samurai swordplay.²²

The next chapters tell the story of how, at roughly the same time, the ruling elite of South-east Asia overwhelmingly converted to the worship of Hindu gods, while Buddhism became increasingly popular, first with the merchant class, then with the ordinary people, so much so that Theravada Buddhism remains the dominant religion today in much of the region. Across South-east Asia, which had until then been speaking a variety of Chinese, Thai and Tibeto-Burman

languages, the elite adopted a very different Indo-European language, Sanskrit, as its courtly lingua franca.

The influence of Indic gods and Indic religions, and the whole scholarly, cultural and linguistic apparatus that came with them, eventually stretched over the greater part of Asia, from Afghanistan in the west to Japan in the east, from Sumatra in the south to Siberia in the north. Indic religions have now dominated Asia's religious, theological, philosophical, cultural, economic and political discourse for almost 2,000 years.

This process culminated in the building of the greatest and most philosophically complex Buddhist structure in the world at Borobudur in Java, and the largest of all Hindu temples, not in India but at Angkor Wat in Cambodia. At Angkor, the temple covers over 500 acres. Beyond extended the palace, pleasure lakes and the quarters of the Khmer capital city, a complex so vast they can be seen from space. Angkor is not just the largest of all Indic temples, but the most spectacular religious structure in the world: the area within the moat is, on its own, four times the size of the Vatican City.

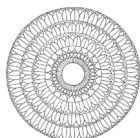
By the twelfth century, the Khmer Empire was at its height and stretched across the region, controlling, with varying degrees of authority, modern Cambodia, Vietnam, Thailand and Laos. At this moment of climax, it arguably had the widest geographical reach of any Hindu empire, embracing as it did almost all of mainland South-east Asia at a time when South Asia was fractured into a mosaic of competing states and polities. At that point it also dwarfed its only Christian rival, that of the Byzantines.

The Khmers were consummate hydraulic engineers. For hundreds of miles around Angkor, a dense network of villages was set amid a patchwork of fields, canals and reservoirs that controlled the monsoon floodwaters to enable wet-rice agriculture. This in turn sustained a population that well exceeded a million people. The great temple complex at the heart of Angkor represented a quantum increase in scale from anything in South Asia and contained many radical stylistic innovations; but it was still firmly based on architectural forms, religious ideas and mythologies that first took shape in India.

This is all the more surprising when one considers the geography of Cambodia, lying as it does so near to China, with a large resident Chinese population and frequent visits by Chinese junks sailing up the waterways of the Mekong. Yet the Khmer kings traced their ancestry

not to Confucius, or any mythical Chinese forebear, but to an Indian named Kaundinya. Nor were Chinese philosophical and religious systems such as Daoism and Confucianism ever successfully exported to Cambodia. Instead it was Hindu and Buddhist gods that were introduced. Buddhism remains the dominant religion in Cambodia and across South-east Asia today.²³

But perhaps it is in scientific rather than spiritual ideas that India stood out most dramatically. Only the ancient Hellenic world equalled it as a powerhouse of new concepts in mathematics and astronomy. By the time of the great fifth-century mathematician Aryabhata (476–550 CE), Indian astronomers had correctly proposed a spherical earth that rotated on its own axis, while using the decimal system and calculating the length of the solar year to an accuracy of seven decimal points. ‘I dived deep in the ocean of astronomical theories, true and false,’ wrote Aryabhata, ‘and rescued the precious sunken jewel of true knowledge by the means of the boat of my own intellect.’²⁴



The final chapters of the book will tell the story of how Indian mathematics, such as the number symbols we still use, the decimal system, algebra, trigonometry and the algorithm as well as astronomical discoveries, first passed from India to Abbasid Baghdad in the late eighth century. There the Abbasid viziers were a family of Sanskrit-literate hereditary Buddhist abbots from Afghanistan who had converted to Islam: the Barmakids.

The father of the first Barmakid vizier of Baghdad, Khalid ibn Barmak, had studied Indian mathematics in Kashmir, then one of the great centres of Indian learning. In Baghdad, the knowledge of ancient India was cross-fertilised with that of ancient Greece. It was his son who sent envoys to India to learn Indian medicine and to the great Indian observatory at Ujjain to study Indian mathematics and astronomy. Both expeditions brought Indian scholars back to Baghdad, where they began the process of translating the Sanskrit scientific classics into Arabic. This established in the heart of the young Muslim world not

just Indian methods of healing and looking at the stars, but a revolutionary Indian concept that would transform mathematics: zero.

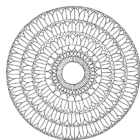
From Baghdad, these ideas spread across the Islamic world. Five hundred years later, in 1205, Leonardo of Pisa, known by his nickname 'Fibonacci', returned from Algeria to Italy with his father. Fibonacci had grown up in a Pisan trading post in Bejaïa, where he had learned fluent Arabic as well as Arab mathematics. Aged thirty-two, he wrote the *Liber Abaci*, the 'Book of Calculation'. It was he who first popularised in Europe the use of what were later thought of as 'Arabic numerals', so seeding the commercial revolution that financed the Renaissance and in time, as these ideas spread north, the economic rise of Europe.

But these numbers were not Arabic in origin. As Fibonacci and his Arab masters recognised, they were Indian. 'When my father held the post of notary at the customs house at Bejaïa, he arranged for me to come to him when I was a boy,' wrote Fibonacci in the introduction to his *Liber Abaci*.

Because he thought it useful for me, he wanted me to spend a few days there in the mathematical school, and to be taught there.

Here I was introduced to a wonderful kind of teaching that used the nine figures of the Indias. With the sign 0, which the Arabs call zephyr (*al-sifr*), any number whatsoever can be written. Getting to know this pleased me far beyond all else ... Therefore concentrating on this method, I made an effort to compose this book, so that those seeking knowledge of this can be instructed by such a perfect method and so that in future the Latin race may not be found lacking this knowledge.²⁵

The roots of these 'nine figures of the Indias' were first written down in the Brahmi script in third-century BCE Bihar, at the time of the Emperor Ashoka. This is something Europeans mostly erased from their memory in recent centuries. It is something they need to retrieve from oblivion today.



If India's transformative effect on the religions and civilisations around it was so central to world history, why is the extraordinary diffusion of its influence not better and more widely known? Some might argue that this is a legacy of colonialism, and more specifically Victorian Indology, which undermined, misrepresented and devalued Indian history, culture, science and knowledge from the period of Macaulay onwards. If India were acknowledged to already have been a powerful, cosmopolitan and profoundly sophisticated civilisation, then what justification would there be for Victorian Britain's civilising mission? How would you set out to bring civilisation to a part of the world that you recognised has been supremely civilised for thousands of years and which indeed was spreading its influence all over Asia long before the coming of Christianity?

Partly, also perhaps, it is because of a tendency today to study this story as separate disciplines, each focusing on different regions and each the preserve of different groups of scholars with different regional specialisations who go to different conferences, and whose objects are then curated in different museum departments.

The many Buddhist monuments and artworks scattered around Afghanistan and China's Taklamakan desert are usually viewed as the first step in the story of the spread of Buddhism through Asia. Conversely, the spread of Indian and especially Hindu culture, literature and religion south-eastwards to Sri Lanka, Burma, Thailand, Cambodia, Vietnam, Laos, Indonesia and the Malay Peninsula tends to be studied as part of the story of the Sanskritisation of Indo-China.

Finally, the extraordinary and little-known story of how Indian mathematics gave the world the numerals we all use today, tends to be studied in Arabic or possibly History of Science departments of universities, as it was through Abbasid Baghdad that Indian ideas of mathematics began their journey westwards. Yet to recount the diffusion of Indian influence during this period as three quite separate processes obscures a more extraordinary story still, and tends to diminish India's role as a major civilisational centre.

There is in addition another reason why the remarkable and catalytic diffusion of early Indian civilisation around Asia is not better known. It lies in the pendulum swings of scholarly fashion. The 1930s and 1940s generation of colonial French historians imagined India's

role in ancient South-east Asia as a civilising colonial mission, rather like that of the French themselves at the time they were writing.

'Mother of Wisdom,' wrote the archaeologist and epigrapher Sylvain Lévi, 'India gave her mythology to her neighbours who went to teach it to the whole world. Mother of law and philosophy, she gave to three-quarters of Asia a god, a religion, a doctrine, an art. She carried her sacred language, her literature, her institutions into Indonesia, to the limits of the known world.' He added, 'She has the right to reclaim, in universal history, the rank that ignorance has refused her for a long time and to hold her place amongst the great nations, summarising and symbolising the spirit of humanity.' Lévi's colleague, George Coedès, wrote in a similar vein that 'the expansion of Indian civilisation to the East ... is one of the outstanding events in the history of the world, one that has determined the destiny of a good portion of mankind'. The great Hindu and Buddhist monuments of South-east Asia may have looked a little different from their counterparts in India, but they were, nonetheless, the 'pure productions of the Indian genius, the deep meaning of which is apparent only to the eyes of the Indianist.'²⁶

The ideas of Lévi and Coedès were eagerly picked up by a generation of Indian intellectuals, many of whom were Bengali and some of whom had attended the University of Paris. In 1926 these nationalist historians founded what they called 'the Greater India Society for the study of Indian culture in East, South-east and Central Asia'. Rabindranath Tagore, the great Nobel Prize-winning poet, was invited to be the *purodha* or 'spiritual guide' of the Society, and they set up their own journal, which continued to publish as late as 1958.²⁷

Many of the contributing members were the finest Indian historians of the day, but – amplifying the preconceptions of their French colonial teachers – their work framed Indian influence in terms of 'Ancient Hindu Colonies in the Far East', as R. C. Majumdar entitled a book that he published in 1944, at the height of the Indian Freedom Struggle, with its talk of 'an inferior civilisation' being overwhelmed and colonised by 'a superior one'.²⁸ Majumdar wrote that Hindu princes had conquered, settled and ruled South-east Asia, which, in Majumdar's telling of it, delighted the locals who 'from this time forward ... cheerfully submitted to their foreign masters and adopted their manners, customs, languages and religion. They were politically

merged in the Indian elements and there was complete cultural fusion between the two races.²⁹ This was, of course, long before the emergence of the idea of 'soft power'.³⁰ In the first Bulletin issued by the Society, Dr Kailas Nag went even further, talking of 'India's noble dynamic of cultural imperialism' which 'soon won for India the ineliable empire over the vast continent, right across Tibet and China to Corea and Japan on the one hand and across Burma and Indo-China to Java and Indonesia on the other.'³¹

There was also a slight tendency among some of these scholars to attribute to India at some point or another nearly all the world's great scientific and mathematical advances, something which was passed on to the laymen of the wider Indian diaspora, and which led to the exaggerations of Sanjeev Bhaskar's celebrated *Goodness Gracious Me* sketch: Christianity? Indian! Leonardo da Vinci? Indian! Royal family? Indian!

In the post-war period, at the height of decolonisation, an historiographical backlash set in. Post-colonial historians from the new nations of South-east Asia, newly freed from the colonial yoke, began to push back against the idea that the formative moments in their history had been the result of any sort of ancient Indian colonialism. These historians strongly objected to the idea that their ancestors were savages, brought to civilisation by sword-wielding Indian adventurers and zealous missionaries of the Brahmin priestly caste. Nor were they thrilled to learn that their homelands were just an extension of 'Greater India'.

They pointed out, rightly, that there was no evidence to show any large-scale Indian military activity in South-east Asia before a series of Chola raids of the eleventh century. Ideas that there were early 'Hindu Colonies' were, they argued, illusory, projecting the evidence of cultural and economic influence much further than was warranted into the political and military sphere. They were also able to show that administratively, South-east Asia was never a part of India before the Chola era, something implied by many nationalistic enthusiasts for Akhand Bharat, or 'Greater India'.

Over the next seventy years, scholars in the region went out of their way to fight off not just the notion of 'Hindu Colonies' but also the whole concept of 'Indianisation' in general, which became almost a dirty word in South-east Asian university departments, to be used only when heavily hedged with inverted commas and qualifying adjectives.

A younger generation of post-colonial archaeologists and art historians working in Vietnam and Cambodia were quick to minimise notions of Indian colonialism, and instead presented their Indic-influenced finds as part of a reciprocal relationship of 'acculturation' and cultural 'convergence' and exchange between India and South-east Asia.³² Many western historians working in the region echoed and amplified these reservations. Meanwhile the Marxist orientation of many Indian historians until recently led to a lack of interest in matters of religion and art, which meant there was little or no pushback from Indian academia.

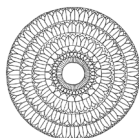
This new generation of archaeologists argued that South-east Asian elites selectively and creatively used and transformed what Indians had brought to the region, constantly adapting rather than slavishly adopting Indian ideas. The sculptures at Angkor Wat, for example, may have been Hindu but they were clearly carved in a completely distinct Khmer style. Moreover, monuments erected in Java and Cambodia were vastly larger than anything in medieval India.

There were also many cases where Hindu or Buddhist ideas from South-east Asia found their way back to India, enhanced and transformed by the work of theologians and artists of Maritime South-east Asia. This loop can be compared to 'the pizza effect ... a Neapolitan dish which flourished and evolved in the US, was further exported around the world, then re-imported back into Italy'.³³ A contemporary parallel to this would be yoga, an Indian practice that flourished globally once it was introduced to the west. New inventions such as 'hot yoga' or 'goat yoga' have been created for which there are no Indian counterparts. Indeed today most of modern 'yoga' is nothing but a fitness regime of physical exercise quite divorced from its Indic religious and philosophical context and with only the most tenuous links to its ancient Indian practice.³⁴ There are historical precedents for this in the way, for example, that Mahayana Buddhism developed its own forms of devotion which proved hugely popular in China and Tibet, but never became dominant in its homeland.

Yet there is still no denying that the cultural flow was overwhelmingly one way: while India did in time take in some Chinese inventions, such as paper and gunpowder, there are no inscriptions in Khmer in

Tamil Nadu, no Indonesian architectural forms in Bengal, no cult of Malay gods in Gujarat. The only inscriptions surviving from South-east Asians in India are in Sanskrit, and record grants to Nalanda partly in order to accommodate expatriate scholars at the monastery university. Equally, it was Indian religions, Indian languages and Indian artistic and architectural forms that were in use from Angkor to Ayutthaya, however much they were subtly changed and transformed in transit.

This was in stark contrast to a much smaller ‘Sinosphere’, effectively limited to Korea, northern Vietnam and Japan, partly because the difficulties presented by the Chinese script, which limited access to Chinese language, literature and civilisation beyond China itself.



The centrality of the Indian subcontinent as one of the two ancient economic and cultural hubs of Asia, and of its ports as the principal places of maritime east–west exchange, has also been partially obscured by the seductively Sinocentric concept of the ‘Silk Road’, an overland trade route said to stretch ever since antiquity all the way across Asia from China to Turkey and the eastern shores of the Mediterranean.

Despite its modern popularity the idea of a Silk Road was completely unknown in ancient or medieval times: not a single ancient record, either Chinese or western, refers to its existence. Instead, it was invented as late as 1877 by a Prussian geographer, Baron von Richthofen, who, while engaged in a geological survey of China, was charged with dreaming up a route for a railway linking Berlin with Beijing with a view to establishing German colonies and infrastructure projects in the region.³⁵ This route he named *die Seidenstraßen*, ‘the Silk Roads’ – the first use of the term.³⁶

It was not until 1938 that the term Silk Road appeared in English, as the title of a popular book by a Swedish explorer, Sven Hedin. Since then, the term has captured the global imagination and the ‘reopening’ of the Silk Road has been announced by President Xi Jinping of China as part of his Belt and Road Initiative. In this way, the idea has been effectively co-opted and actively mobilised as part of Chinese foreign

policy, partly to obfuscate its economic and military projections of power. It has now been elevated to unquestioned fact.³⁷

Following Richthofen, maps of the overland Silk Route linking east and west, the Mediterranean with the South China Sea, often feature a single small arrow pointing south from Kashgar down towards the Himalayas. That arrow is labelled: 'To India'. The real economic action, the map implies, took place between China and western Europe; India was an almost passive observer of, and a lucky recipient of largesse from, the main highway of intercontinental commerce running far to its north.

The reality is very different. Although overland trade routes through Iran were clearly of central importance when Mongol rule stretched from the Mediterranean to the South China Sea during the thirteenth century, this was not the case during the classical and early medieval era. Indeed the Roman Empire and China actually had only the haziest notions of each other's existence – vaguely aware of each other, but almost never in direct contact.

The earliest reference in Chinese sources to an attempt to send an embassy to 'Da Qin' – usually identified as Rome – is as late as 97 CE. It failed to reach its destination.³⁸ As one Roman guide to the commerce of the Indian Ocean put it, 'Beyond this region at the northernmost point, where the sea ends somewhere on the outer fringe, there is a very great inland city called Thina [China] from which silk floss, yarn and cloth are shipped by land via Bactria [Afghanistan] to Barygaza [in modern Gujarat] and via the Ganges River back to Limyrike [Kerala]. It is not easy to get to this Thina.'³⁹

In reality, goods from China largely reached Rome merely as an exotic supplement to its thriving commerce with India, and passed through Indian ports.⁴⁰ For, from the time of Augustus (r. 31 BCE–14 CE), for several centuries, Rome and ancient India were major trading partners, with hundreds of huge cargo ships passing directly between the two each year. Roman trading manuals reveal a real, practical familiarity, even intimacy, with the ports of India, especially those on the west coast, with detailed descriptions that clearly derive from first-hand experience and direct observation. If China and Rome ever came face to face, they did so here in the quays, ports and bazaars of coastal India.

In contrast, the Silk Route barely existed in antiquity, at least as Richthofen had imagined it. For while goods certainly passed

backwards and forwards as part of local or regional trade, with some objects eventually moving long distances, there was never, at any point in history, any one east–west overland trade route linking the China Sea with the Mediterranean. Nor was there any free movement of goods between China and the west at any point before the Mongol period in the thirteenth century. Marco Polo, the man now most closely associated with the so-called Silk Road, never once mentions the term, even though it was during his lifetime that travel became easiest through the borderless enormity of the vast Mongol Empire.⁴¹

Even silk, the most celebrated Chinese export, arrived in Roman lands only indirectly, usually by boat, via India, where much of the silk that reached the west was actually manufactured.⁴² As late as the age of Augustus most Roman writers mention only the coarse silk produced on the island of Cos. Both Vergil and Seneca writing in the first half of the first century CE confidently assert that silk grew on trees.⁴³ This would seem to indicate that the importance of silk to the classical west has been exaggerated.

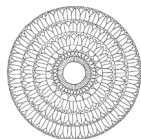
Silk was never the main commodity imported to the west from the east. Instead, it was always far exceeded in value by imports of Indian pepper, spices, ivory, cotton, gems, teak and sandalwood. When in 408 CE Alaric the Visigoth held Rome to ransom, his terms were significant: in addition to 5,000 pounds of gold, he demanded not silk but 3,000 pounds of Indian black pepper.⁴⁴

This is partly why only a handful of Roman coins have ever turned up in China – just a few scattered finds and a single hoard, of uncertain date, containing sixteen coins representing different emperors from Tiberius to Aurelian.⁴⁵ On the other hand, Roman coins are found today by archaeologists in India in their tens of thousands, as they have been since the eighteenth century, when East India Company factors in Madras first began reporting the discovery of ‘five cooly-loads’ of Roman gold coins, as well as ‘some thousands’ of silver coins.⁴⁶ This is especially so in Kerala and Tamil Nadu, where hoards are still being found every year, mostly dating from the heyday of the Red Sea trade route during the first century.⁴⁷ The museums of India probably contain more Roman coins than those of any other country outside the boundaries of the Roman empire.⁴⁸ This gold was the economic engine of early Indic cultural power.

Later, when the Roman trade collapsed as a result of a Persian blockade and the loss of the Red Sea to the Arabs, Indian merchants found a new source of gold from South-east Asia. It was only in the thirteenth century when the catastrophe of the Mongol invasions wrecked the old trade routes that the Golden Road finally began to break down. Moreover, India was cut off by a hostile border from the overland trade routes that now stretched, under a single dominion, from the China Sea to the Mediterranean.

Now, superseding trade routes focused primarily on the maritime trade of India, with its annual monsoon winds taking merchandise backwards and forwards at speed, a new trade network was born. This brought goods through the deserts and oases of Central Asia. In 1271, thanks to the Pax Mongolica, Marco Polo and his uncles would be able, more or less for the first time, to travel under a single passport from Jerusalem to Xanadu, so helping to open up a new direct, barrier-free and overland transcontinental trade route.

This was the network of trade routes that would later be called the Silk Roads.



In contrast to India, China has become very good at telling the story that it was always the centre of the Asian world.

The highly nationalistic and Sinocentric reframing and rebranding of history portrayed the trading world of the Silk Roads in idealised terms as a network of peaceful global exchange centred on China, which was depicted as the principal economic engine powering world trade.⁴⁹ Since Xi Jinping launched his idea of the Belt and Road, with a promised investment pot of \$1 trillion in infrastructure loans, this narrative has become highly politicised and there is much talk of the Belt and Road as a 'New Silk Road'.⁵⁰ India has done little to counter this, though there have been some half-hearted attempts to portray its trade relations with the Middle East in terms of a 'Cotton Road', or, more recently, an 'India–Middle East–Europe Economic Corridor', known as IMEC.⁵¹

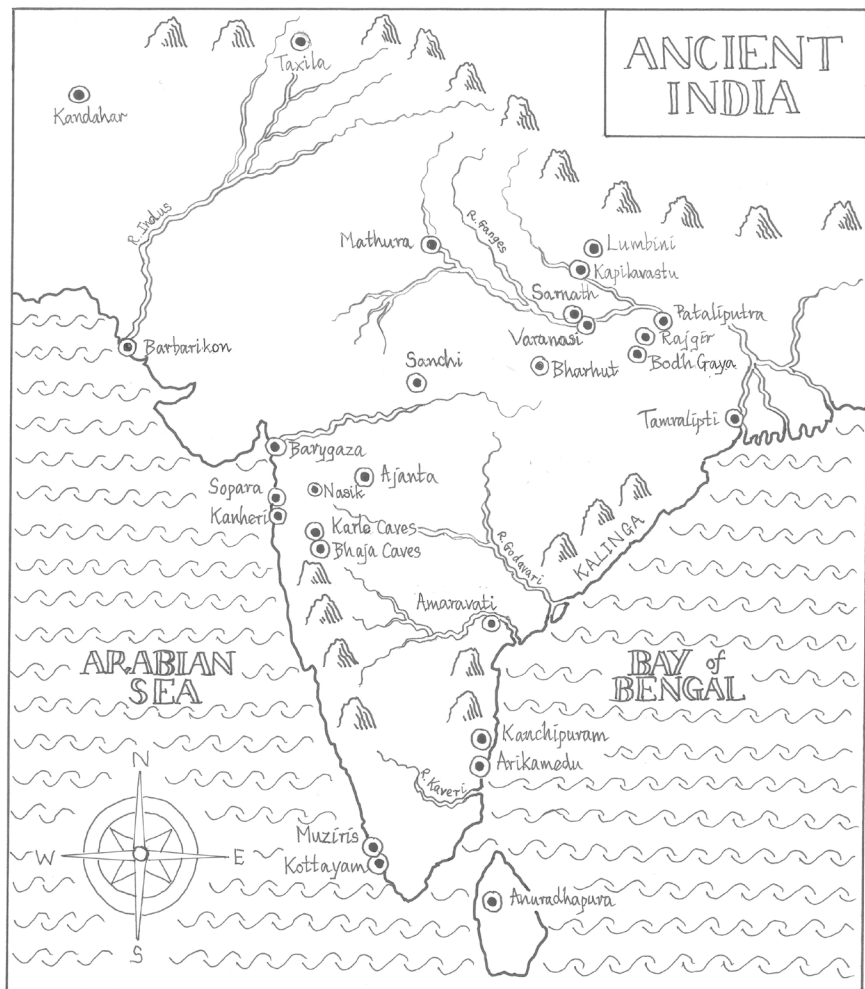
But history tells a quite different story. In the crucial period between the end of antiquity and the onset of the high Middle Ages, you can make at least as good a case for India being the cultural and intellectual centre of Asia, influencing and changing the course of religious, artistic and cultural life in all the regions around it, not least in China itself. This after all was why Xuanzang, and many others like him, risked their lives to make the dangerous journey to what was then the Harvard or MIT of ancient Asia: the great Buddhist university of Nalanda.

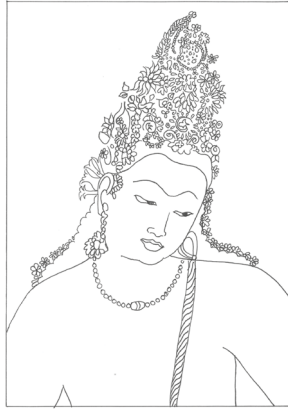
Unlike China, India was rarely even partially united in ancient times – when Xuanzang reached what he regarded as the geographical borders of India at Jallalabad in the seventh century CE, he remarked that he was entering a holy land, ‘the Five Indias’, made up of ‘more than seventy’ distinct kingdoms.^{52, 53} But, for all its political fragmentation, the idea of India as a single cultural, sacral and geographical unit was still clearly understood from the very earliest times.

Xuanzang was not alone in having a clear understanding of the geographical boundaries of the fractured land he called India: his fifth-century CE predecessor, the Chinese monk Faxian, had similar ideas of a country ‘triangular in shape, broad in the north and narrow in the south’.⁵⁴ Before that, the historian Strabo tells how Alexander the Great talked to sadhus who conceived of their homeland as stretching ‘from the mouth of the Indus in the west to the mouth of the Ganges in the east, from the mouth of the Ganges to the tip of southern India, and from there, again, to the mouth of the Indus’.⁵⁵ The *Mahabharata*, which was in the process of composition at around the same time, gives an even more concise definition: ‘the land north of the seas and south of the Himalayas is called Bharata, where the descendants of King Bharata lived’.⁵⁶

This India, or Bharat, however defined, was one of the two great intellectual and philosophical superpowers of ancient Asia, fully the equal to China in the broader ancient world. It set the template for the way much of the world would think and express itself, and would significantly alter the trajectory of the history of a great swathe of mankind. For more than a thousand years it was a garden that issued the seeds that, once planted elsewhere, flowered in new, rich and unexpected ways.

Exactly how it did so is the subject of this book.





I

A Gale of Stillness

In the early summer of 1819, a British hunting party was heading through thick jungle near Aurangabad in the Deccan when the tiger they were tracking disappeared into a deep ravine.

Leading the party was Captain John Smith, a young cavalry officer from Madras. Beckoning his friends to follow, he tracked the pugmarks down a semi-circular scarp of steep basalt and hopped across the rocky bed of the Waghur river. He then made his way slowly up through the bushes at the far side of the steep horseshoe-shaped amphitheatre of cliffs. Halfway up, Smith stopped dead in his tracks.¹

The pug prints led straight past an opening in the rock face. But the cavity was clearly not a natural cave or a river-cut grotto. Instead, despite the long grass, the all-encroaching creepers, pepper vines and thick, thorny undergrowth, Smith could see that he was looking at a man-made façade cut straight into the rock face. The jagged slope had been painstakingly etched away into a perfect portico. It was clearly a work of great sophistication. It was equally clear that it had been abandoned for centuries.

A few minutes later, the party made their way gingerly inside, as Smith held aloft a makeshift torch of burning dried grass and his companions clutched their muskets. A long hall, a hundred feet long

by forty feet wide, led right into the living rock, flanked on either side by thirty-nine octagonal pillars. At the apse-shaped end rose the circular dome of a Buddhist stupa carved, like everything else, out of the solid rock of the mountain.

Through the gloom, the officers could see the shadowy outlines of ancient murals. On the pillars were figures of orange-robed monks with white haloes standing on blue lotuses, while on the rock walls were painted panels filled with elaborate crowd scenes, rather as if a painted scroll had been rolled out along the wall of the apse. In the light of the flickering flame, the officers could dimly make out what they later described as 'figures with curled wigs'. Crunching over a human skeleton and other debris dragged into the cave by generations of predators and scavengers, the party advanced step by step until they reached a pillar at the far end of the hall, next to the stupa. There Smith got out his hunting knife and inscribed over the body of a heavenly being the words: 'JOHN SMITH, 28th CAVALRY, 28 APRIL 1819'.²

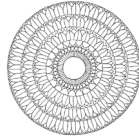
In the decades to come, first other hunting parties, then later groups of archaeologists and Indologists, followed in Smith's footsteps through the jungle of the Western Ghats to Ajanta as word spread that in this most remote spot lay thirty caves which collectively amounted to one of the great wonders of the ancient world. Two of the caves – Cave 9 and Cave 10 – were soon recognised as some of the oldest completely intact man-made rooms in Asia: from palaeographic evidence, scholars believe they were dug out between 90 and 70 BCE, and so completed several generations before Augustus started rebuilding Rome.

On the walls of the caves of Ajanta were found some of the most beautiful and ancient paintings in Buddhist art. Most of these dated from the fifth century CE, an otherwise lost Golden Age of Indian painting. Along with the frescoes of Pompeii and Herculaneum, the delicate murals of Livia's Garden House outside Rome and of Nero's Golden House within the city's walls, Ajanta's walls represented perhaps the most comprehensive depiction of courtly life to survive from classical antiquity anywhere in the world.³

The Ajanta murals relayed Buddhist stories in images of supreme elegance and grace. Unlike the flatter art of later Indian miniature painting, here the artists used perspective and foreshortening to produce paintings of courtly life and ascetic renunciation, hunts, battles and erotic liaisons

that rank as some of the greatest masterpieces of art produced by mankind in any century. Most beautiful of all are the two astonishing images which probably depict the compassionate Bodhisattvas, Avalokitesvara and Vajrapani, beings on the threshold of Enlightenment who consciously chose to delay crossing over in order to help others who are struggling on the same path. These beings of otherworldly beauty, elegance and compassion are shown with their eyes half closed, inward-looking, weightlessly swaying on the threshold of Enlightenment, caught in what the great historian of Indian art, Stella Kramrisch, described, wonderfully, as ‘a gale of stillness’.⁴

Even today, the colours of these murals glow with a brilliant intensity: lizard-green, topaz-yellow, lotus-blue.



In 2014, restoration work in Ajanta Cave 10 uncovered extraordinary new fragments of very early Buddhist murals, dating from the late first century BCE – a full 500 years earlier than the celebrated murals of Cave 1. Cave 10 is now known to contain a supreme treasure not previously properly identified or studied: the oldest surviving murals telling the Jataka stories of the different lives of the Buddha.⁵

One particularly well-preserved scene shows a group of kings and deities venerating a Bodhi tree and a stupa. This is an image of the Buddha’s first sermon at Sarnath, with the tree taking the place of the Saviour: at this stage in Buddhist art it was considered unacceptable to depict the actual person of the Buddha, so his followers showed him represented at one remove through symbols such as a turban or an empty throne. It was through these narratives that they introduced non-Buddhists to the complex cosmologies and rich mythology of the new faith.

This earliest surviving mural illustrated the life and teachings of a young prince named Siddhartha Gautama, the son of a king who ruled the small kingdom of Kapilavastu on the borderlands of India and Nepal in the mid-fifth century BCE.⁶ At the age of twenty-nine, Siddhartha renounced his kingdom and became a *sramana*, ‘one who strives’, a spiritual reformer whose life’s work was to seek a solution

to the age-old problem of human suffering. In his lifetime he was given the title 'Shakyamuni', the Sage of the Shakya clan. Today, we know him as the Buddha.

The Buddha's teachings had long been lost in most of India by the time Ajanta was rediscovered. Even the fact that he was of Indian origin had been forgotten across most of his homeland. Yet Siddhartha was very much the product of the religious and philosophical world of the fifth century BCE, born at a time of rapid change, social disorientation, spiritual crisis and churning across Eurasia that produced not only the new religious thought of the Buddha and Mahavira in India but also the works of Confucius in China and Sophocles in Greece. New technologies, especially the iron plough and improved weaponry, had led to a dramatic shift in the way people lived, transforming many societies from a wandering life of nomadic pastoralism to settled farming, and with it the rise of cities, trade and a highly stratified social structure.⁷

The fire sacrifices that had been the staple of the early Hinduism of the Vedas, composed a thousand years or more before the birth of the Buddha, were designed for a nomadic and tribal society; but in the flux of change as India urbanised these had begun to give way to increasingly elaborate and expensive ceremonies, sometimes involving the mass slaughter of large numbers of animals. Many seem to have yearned for a move away from blood sacrifices and towards religious practice more focused on good conduct and ethics. At the same time, the solidifying of the caste system and growing ideas of ritual purity had led to great social discontent. In response, many new belief systems emerged: some historians estimate that as many as sixty-six new heterodox creeds appear around this time, and there is no evidence that, in the region occupied by the historical Buddha, Brahminical Hinduism had successfully imposed itself as the dominant religious culture.⁸ Instead, the world of the Buddha was filled with wandering holy men and yogis preaching a bewildering variety of unorthodox religious paths.

One of these was the austere way of extreme asceticism, self-discipline and self-mortification embraced by Mahavira (599–529 BCE), another disillusioned north Indian aristocrat who had probably lived not long before the Buddha, and whose spiritual journey seems to have inspired the young Prince. Mahavira had renounced the world at the age of thirty to found a non-violent religious system that in time grew to become the Jain faith. As a Jain monk explains

to a group of hostile Brahmins in one of the most ancient Jain scriptures, the most important sacrifice for Jains is not some priestly ritual, but the sacrifice of one's own body. 'Austerity is my sacrificial fire,' says the monk, 'and my life is the place where the fire is kindled. Mental and physical effort are my ladle for the oblation, and my body is the dung fuel for the fire, my actions my firewood. I offer up an oblation praised by the wise seers consisting of my restraint, effort and calm.'⁹

Mahavira's ideas initially appealed to Prince Siddhartha. According to Buddhist tradition, during his youth the Buddha had been sheltered from the horrors of the world by his loving father who refused to let his son leave the palace. But when the cosseted Prince, aided by a faithful servant, broke out and first encountered suffering, old age, disease and death, he was horrified by his belated exposure to human pain. Distraught and suddenly disillusioned with his comfortable and privileged life, he abandoned both his father's kingdom and his pregnant wife, and set off on a lonely quest to understand the roots of suffering, in an attempt to find a way to escape it.

Like many others at that time, the Buddha renounced worldly attachments and retreated to the wilderness, adopting the life of a wandering ascetic under the tutelage of a variety of teachers. He initially tried the path of extreme asceticism and rigorous penance, similar to that followed by Mahavira. 'My body became extremely lean,' said the Buddha according to one relatively early account of his life. 'When I thought I would touch the skin of my stomach, I actually took hold of my spine.'¹⁰

But asceticism was not the answer – it led only to more suffering – and the Buddha eventually abandoned intense self-denial in favour of his own solution to the problem. This was what he described as the Middle Path: the way of moderation between the extremes of self-torture and sensual indulgence, between worldliness and asceticism. His physical and mental discipline led to perfect control over his mind and body, and at the age of thirty-five, sitting under a sacred pipal tree and meditating without moving for forty-nine days, he at last achieved Enlightenment – and, with it, freedom from greed, hate and delusion. He realised that this moment of *bodhi* or 'awakening' (after which the religion was named) derived not from the punishing of his body but instead from simply learning the way to extinguish desire.

In his sermons, the Buddha explained how the force generated by a person's actions – karma – driven by desire and attachments bound one to a long cycle of *samsara*, or 'rebirth'. An early Buddhist text named the *Vinaya Pitaka* gives the Buddha's own explanation of his approach to a new disciple named Sona:

Formerly, when you were a householder, were you skilled at playing the lute?

Yes, Lord.

When the strings of the lute were too taut, was it tuneful and fit for playing?

Certainly not, Lord.

And when they were slack, was the lute tuneful and fit for playing?

No, Lord.

But when the strings were neither too taut nor too slack but were keyed to an even pitch, was your lute tuneful and fit for playing?

Yes, Lord.

Even so, Sona, is the *dharma* that I propose.¹¹

From this moment of revelation, the Buddha wandered through northern India teaching his fundamental ideas that everything is impermanent and that desire brings only the most fleeting of pleasures. The material world is ultimately an illusion, said the Buddha, a dream from which everyone must sooner or later awaken. Material pleasures 'are like a man who dreams of a fine house with fine gardens and luxurious delights. Yet when he awakens all of it vanishes. Distinctions of wealth and poverty, noble and common, are like a dream.'¹² The Buddha also taught his own solution to this problem: the *dharma* or moral path to the cessation of both desire and suffering. He passed on this message of remarkable emotional simplicity and clarity not in the complex Sanskrit of the Brahmins, but instead in the common Prakrit vernacular of the ordinary people.

The doctrine of the Buddha was at once a philosophy, an ideology and a method, a practical spiritual path of mental training and discipline that he assured his followers would free them from the pain inherent in existence. He questioned the claim of the Brahmins that the Vedas, the foundations of what would become known as Hinduism, were the

infallible, divine source of spiritual truth and rejected their rituals as the means to salvation; he even disavowed the intellectual approach of more recent Hindu texts such as the Upanishads.¹³ His message was instead based on love, kindness, compassion, detachment, non-violence, as well as intense meditation and personal self-discovery.

It was open to all and required no priestly intervention nor any rituals or sacrifices. Instead, it required only trust in the truths laid down by Buddha, his *dharma*, and the monastic community that he founded to keep his message alive. By following this path, he said, others could follow him in breaking free from the cycles of rebirth and the bonds of *samsara*, and so becoming Enlightened or Awakened Ones. In this way they could obtain nirvana, which means simply 'a flame blown out by the wind'.¹⁴

Nowhere does this world of the Buddha come more dramatically to life than in Ajanta, its earliest surviving expression in paint. The murals take us to an ancient world so astonishingly lifelike that even today, even in reproduction, the images of the Buddha's life can still make you gasp as you find yourself eyeball to eyeball with a watching monk who may have attended one of the early councils that gave shape to the Buddhist faith or with an Indian warrior who may have fought one of the battles over his relics.

So faithfully lifelike and realistic are the faces of the people depicted, so direct are their expressions, that you feel that these have to be portraits of real individuals, glowing still with the flame of eternal life. There is none of the idealisation or otherworldliness you see in the later images of the Bodhisattvas. Instead there is something deeply hypnotic about the soundless stare of these silent, often uncertain, early Buddhist faces. Their fleeting expressions are frozen, startled, as if suddenly surprised by the King of Varanasi's decision to loose his arrow or by the nobility of the great elephant breaking through the trees.

Indeed there is a profound sadness in the cycle of paintings, which are concerned with issues of justice, peace and non-violence: one image tells of a war breaking out over the Buddha's relics – something that went totally against the grain of everything he taught. This is followed by three Jataka scenes which all tell of the unjust killing of an innocent: successively, the loving wife of a king who is falsely accused of trying to kill him; the shooting of a boy as he fetches water for his

parents in the forest; and a noble elephant king murdered by hunters for his tusks.¹⁵ The viewer peers at these figures trying to catch some hint of the upheavals they witnessed and the strange sights they saw in ancient India. But these smooth, open, humane Indian faces, so full of melancholy, stare us down.

The most disconcerting thing about the people in these murals is that they appear so familiar. Two thousand years after they were painted, these faces convey with penetrating immediacy the character of the different sitters: the alert guard, the King caught in the excitement of the hunt, the obedient son fetching water. Indeed, so contemporary are the features, so immediately recognisable the emotions that play on the lips, that you have to keep reminding yourself that these sitters are not from our world, that they depict a court and jungle world of hunters and hunted, and Buddhist monks and devotees, that vanished from these hills more than two millennia ago.

But perhaps the biggest surprise is that the world portrayed in the murals is only occasionally one of lonely self-sacrifice or of stark ascetic renunciation – a shaven-headed, orange-robed monk lost in meditation, a hermit seeking salvation in the gloom of a rock-cut grotto, or a group of wizened devotees straining to hear the words of their teacher. This is what we might expect in a Buddhist mural. What we do not expect are scenes showing a prosperous and multicultural palatial environment full of riches and pleasures and beauty, and thronged with courtiers wearing jewels and enjoying music, shady bowers and the many pleasures of youth.

Surprisingly, at Ajanta the Buddha tends to be shown less in his monastic milieu and more often in the princely environment in which he grew up. Here among handsome princes and bare-chested nobles, princesses with tiaras of *raat-ki-rani*, Queen of the Night jasmine, languish lovelorn on swings and couches, while heavy-breasted and narrow-waisted dancing girls, dressed in diaphanous robes, jewels and girdles, perform beside lotus ponds, swaying to unheard music, ringing their *ghungroo* anklets. These court women wear little but spinels and chrysoberyl cat's eyes; they hold nothing but empurpled ebony flywhisks of burnished gold; gleaming rubies the colour of peacocks' blood flash against their dark skin.

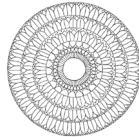
The artists of Ajanta clearly saw nothing odd in this juxtaposition of monks and dancing girls, ascetics and princesses. There are no panels

or boundaries in the Ajanta paintings beyond the physical borders of the cave, and the artists move from the world of the ascetic's cave to the pleasure gardens of the royal court and back again without acknowledging any essential separation between the two.

There is also a surprisingly international cast of characters in the murals. Recognisable among the crowds are many foreigners, including Persians, Parthians, Scythians, Ethiopians, Egyptians and even Greeks and Romans, each with distinct clothes, tunics, hairstyles, skin colours and drinking goblets. Even the pigments used in the paintings indicate international connections – the gorgeous blue, for example, was obtained from lapis lazuli imported from Badakshan. Ajanta was evidently built at the centre of a deeply globalised world.¹⁶

The earliest caves of Ajanta contain inscriptions which show that the whole enterprise of their excavation was the result of numerous small contributions, partly from pious monks and nuns, but also from local merchant guilds and craftsmen. The murals indicate that, by the time of Ajanta, India was not some self-contained island of Indianness, but already a cosmopolitan and surprisingly urban society full of traders from all over the world; in many cases it was the traders themselves who actually paid for these murals, such as the rich merchant Ghanamadada who, according to an inscription, donated the funds for Cave 12. To some extent, the murals may also have reflected the merchants' taste, which could explain the near absence of asceticism or even monasticism in the murals.

Either way, it is clear, the message of the Buddha was no longer restricted to any one caste or class or tribe. It was universal, and like later missionary religions was intended to be spread to the ends of the earth.



How did the ideas of an obscure ascetic begin their extraordinary journey around the world?

For its first 200 years, from the fifth to the third century BCE, Buddhism is almost completely invisible in the archaeological record. There are no inscriptions. Not one Buddhist text survives from the period and only a handful of early Buddhist sites show even the slightest

hint of occupation.¹⁷ Those that do tend to be located in the same small area of the plains of north-east India and Nepal, bordering the banks of the Ganges, where the Buddha had lived and preached.

One such site is the monastery at Rajgir, the 'Mountain of the King', sixty miles from Patna, said to have been built by the physician Jivaka in the Buddha's lifetime, whose ruinous rectangular halls of simple rubble have been dated by archaeologists to the fifth century BCE. Then there are a pair of small early stupas: one is at Vaisali, the capital of the powerful Licchavi clan; and the other is the site of the Buddha's birth at Lumbini. Here archaeologists discovered a small saucer-shaped mud burial mound that was dug into during the mid-third century BCE, apparently to extract the relics within. It must therefore have dated from before that period. From the same period, the archaeologists also discovered a wooden structure surrounding a small courtyard lying within the Maya Devi Temple, the site of the grove where the Buddha was born.¹⁸

The man who ordered the excavation of this early stupa and extracted the Buddha's relics is the first Indian whose voice survives for us in his own words, or who has left us texts written in stone in any comprehensible Indian script. The Emperor Ashoka was one of the most remarkable figures in all Indian history. He was also the man who helped raise Buddhism from what was still effectively a relatively small, even local cult, into one of the world's great religions.¹⁹

Ashoka's family, the Mauryas, first come into historical focus just after the invasion of the Punjab by Alexander the Great in the fourth century BCE, as the Macedonian conqueror burned Persepolis and pursued the last Achaemenid Emperor, Darius III, into the furthest satrapies of the Persian Empire, in what is now Afghanistan and Pakistan.

When the victorious Alexander arrived on the banks of the Indus in the summer of 327 BCE, the King of Taxila wisely decided against challenging the Greeks. Instead, he met Alexander in Swat and guided him through the forests of rhododendron and alpine clematis to the walls of the city. Here, for the first time, Alexander's troops were able to rest and take in the Indian scene. To the Greeks, familiar with the glories of Athens, Babylon, Susa and Egyptian Memphis, the buildings of Taxila were unremarkable: the houses were made of mud and uncut stone, and were laid out without any central order or plan.

But what did amaze them were the peoples who lived there. ‘Physically, the Indians are slim,’ wrote Alexander’s Admiral, Nearchus.

They are tall and much lighter in weight than other men ... they wear earrings of ivory (at least the rich do), and they dye their beards, some the very whitest of white, others dark blue, red or purple or even green ... they wear a tunic and throw an outer mantle around their shoulders: another is wound round their head. All except the very humblest carry parasols in summer.²⁰

Others wore no clothes at all. Two miles outside Taxila, the Greeks came across fifteen naked and motionless gymnosophists (‘naked wise men’), Indian holy men, who the Greeks say were ‘Brahmins and *sramans*’ (that is, Hindus and ascetics, probably Buddhists or Digambara Jains). The gymnosophists laughed at the Greeks’ cloaks and knee-high boots and told them to undress if they wanted to talk.²¹ ‘But the heat of the sun’, wrote one of Alexander’s men, ‘was so scorching that nobody could have borne to walk barefoot, especially at midday.’

So the Greeks kept their clothes on, and the senior guru questioned them about Socrates, Pythagoras and Diogenes. One of the Holy Men ‘gave a discourse in which he stated that “the best teaching is that which removes pleasure and pain from the soul”, a phrase which has a Buddhist ring to it.’²² Later, the gurus, still naked, dined at Alexander’s table. ‘[They] ate their food while standing,’ wrote one witness, ‘balanced on one leg.’ One of the leading gymnosophists, whom the Greeks called Calanus, followed the troops and took on pupils among the Macedonians. He became mortally ill in Babylon in 323 BCE and decided to throw himself on a ritual funeral pyre. He met his end with complete composure, to the amazement of the watching Greeks.²³

Another of Alexander’s soldiers may well have brought the ideas of Buddhism back to the Peloponnese. The sceptic philosopher and poet Pyrrho of Elis (c.360–270 BCE) was with Alexander in India in the 330s BCE and according to his third-century biographer, Diogenes Laertius, he was profoundly influenced by ‘the doctrines of the gymnosophists’.

On his return to Greece, he adopted a life of wandering and austerity, living in solitude and avoiding what he regarded as the pointless

seduction of sensual pleasures. He explained to his followers that the only way to avoid suffering and unhappiness was to control desire and reject the passions, to cultivate instead equanimity, indifference and suspension of judgement. He embraced a position of agnosticism and, according to one account, practised an early form of yoga, remaining 'in a single position, unmoved, all day long'. This, he said, would result in 'an undisturbed mental state' of deep calm, peace and 'inner and outer tranquillity' and a life 'free from suffering'.²⁴

According to the prolific Greek historian and philosopher Plutarch (46–120 CE), at the same time as Alexander met the gymnosophists he also encountered a young Indian warrior whose family would do far more to spread Buddhism over a far wider area even than Pyrrho. Chandragupta Maurya was a political refugee from Magadha, modern Bihar. He was completing his education in Taxila, a great centre of learning, which had been home to the Sanskrit grammarian Panini and the political scientist Kautilya.²⁵ Plutarch records that 'Sadrocottus [the Greek name for Chandragupta], when he was a stripling, saw Alexander, and we are told that he often said in later times that Alexander missed making himself master of India, since its king was hated and despised on account of his baseness and low birth.' According to later Jain sources, Chandragupta hero-worshipped the Macedonian, joined Alexander's army and eventually determined to emulate his conquests.²⁶

Alexander fought one last great battle before he left India, the Battle of the Hydaspes River; if the late Jain sources are to be believed, Chandragupta could well have been present on the Greek side. Alexander's opponent was Porus, King of the Punjab, who fought with an army led by a force of massed elephants. Alexander defeated the Raja in a bloody monsoon battle in which the badly wounded King of the Punjab remained perched on his elephant, encouraging his men to fight on. When captured, he refused to bow to Alexander and when asked how he should be treated replied, 'like a king'.²⁷

Impressed by his bravery and dignity in defeat, Alexander reinstated him in power as his deputy. It was a battle that clearly meant a lot to Alexander as he produced a set of gold and silver commemorative coins with his head on one side and on the reverse an image of himself on horseback attacking Porus' elephant.

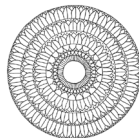
Alexander was amazed and excited by the remarkable prosperity of India and the number of well-ordered cities that greeted his forces

as they advanced south and east.²⁸ But on the banks of the Jhelum Alexander's soldiers – wet, footsore, homesick and far from home – refused to advance any further. Alexander was forced to head for home, never to return.²⁹

It was the power vacuum that followed Alexander's departure that the young Chandragupta Maurya (ruled c.320–297 BCE) determined to fill. In due course, he overthrew the Nanda kings of northern India and established a new empire that included much territory that until then had been under the rule first of the Persians of Persepolis and then of the Macedonian Greeks.

By 320 BCE, Chandragupta had defeated his Indian rivals and consolidated his hold on the Gangetic plain. He then acquired the north-west provinces of India from Alexander's successor Seleucus, one of the Macedonian's original Companions, who had commanded the infantry at the Battle of the Hydaspes; the two men may have fought shoulder to shoulder. Chandragupta gained this territory in exchange for 500 (out of his 9,000) war elephants and an alliance sealed by the marriage of one of his sons to the daughter of Seleucus.³⁰ He also threw in a basket of Indian aphrodisiacs which he said would make the Greeks 'as randy as birds'.³¹ The alliance continued into the next generation. In one exchange, Chandragupta asked Seleucus' half-Bactrian son, Antiochus, to send him sweet wine, dried figs and a sophist. Antiochus replied that he would send the wine and the figs, but that 'Greek laws forbade him to send a sophist'.³²

After Chandragupta had abdicated in 297 BCE, to become a Jain monk, his son Bindusara continued to cultivate good relations with his Greek neighbours.³³ It was Chandragupta's grandson Ashoka who continued his career of conquest into what is now Afghanistan. He would be remembered in Buddhist sources as the man who helped Buddhism spread far beyond the boundaries of India.³⁴



Under Ashoka, the Mauryan Empire grew into the largest empire India had yet seen, while its capital, Pataliputra, modern Patna, became quite probably the largest city in the world. According to the

report of Megasthenes, a Greek ambassador who visited just before Ashoka was born, the city already covered ten square miles and was surrounded by a wall twenty-one miles long broken by sixty-four gates and 570 towers. This meant it was around twice the size of early Rome, three times the size of Alexandria and eleven times larger than Athens, with a population of some 200,000.

Pataliputra was a profoundly cosmopolitan place, in close diplomatic, military and cultural contact with the adjoining Seleucid Empire which stretched from Bactria through Persia to Anatolia, and with whose Greek kings the Mauryan family had intermarried.³⁵ Ashoka in his youth was sent as viceroy to Taxila, which still had a large Greek population, left stranded in India after the death of Alexander in Babylon.

By 261 BCE, around 250 years after the death of the Buddha, Ashoka's lands stretched, with varying degrees of authority, from Kandahar to the Deccan. Ashoka then decided to wage war on his most formidable rivals. The Kalinga kingdom was based in modern Odisha and stretched down the prosperous east coast of India. The prolonged and bloody campaign to crush the Kalingas was militarily successful and led to Ashoka exercising overlordship over a larger area of the Indian subcontinent than anyone else before British colonial rule; but it also resulted in terrible carnage and destruction.³⁶

Ashoka, ironically for a man whose name means 'without sorrow', suffered intense guilt for the pain, misery and devastation he had caused. He may already have shown favour to the Buddhists in his kingdom; but this was no longer enough, and his interest in the teachings of the Buddha deepened.³⁷ He began visiting the sites associated with the Buddha's life and decided to let his Buddhist faith guide his policies, indeed to put the propagation of Buddhism at the very centre of his rule. 'More than two and a half years have passed since I became a Buddhist layman,' he records, 'but I was not zealous. Now more than a year has passed since I approached the Sangha [Buddhist monastic community] and I have become much more ardent and committed.'³⁸

The edicts he ordered to be carved on rocks around his empire as a sort of early public-address system record his motivation. During the Kalinga war, he wrote,

One hundred and fifty thousand people were deported, one hundred thousand were killed and many times that number perished ...